BUILDING FOR THE PEOPLE

After having recently been awarded the Royal Gold Medal by the Royal Institute of British Architects, **B.V. "Balkrishna" Doshi**, 94, says he would like to be remembered as a "humanitarian architect"

Q+A

Q. You've worked with masters of modernism like Corbusier & Louis Kahn but you acknowledge Le Corbusier as your guru. Give an example of his influence on you?
Visiting my drafting table, Corbusier explained to me the intricacies of space, movement, light and structure. He would describe the movement of people in it. I was transported to these buildings which he drew on the paper but didn't exist in reality. This is what influenced me greatly.

Q. Your many honours include the Pritzker prize, known as the Nobel Prize of architecture. Why is RIBA's Gold Medal special?
My association with RIBA early in my career played an important role in my architectural education. I used to spend hours at the RIBA library. Those memories make this special for me. In the late 50s, I was with Le Corbusier when he received RIBA's Gold Medal. For me, to get the Royal Gold Medal that my guru got is even more humbling and gratifying.

Q. From low-income housing projects to multiple institutions, such as IITs, your range is vast. But what is the genre that has been most satisfying–and why?
Low-cost housing has been the most gratifying work for me. I believe that you must give something to people–give them a reason to smile, joy to celebrate, and the security to celebrate life.



RAJWANT RAWAT

Q. Your artworks–paintings, metal sculpture and drawings–were recently shown at Art Basel. Do your building sketches inspire the art or vice versa?
I cannot distinguish one from the other–to me, they are integral. When I draw something, it happens naturally because it is unexpected. And when I design buildings, I try to find ways by which the spirit comes through.

–with Sunil Sethi